

CONCEPT PAPER — ONE OF THREE

Kaia plans the trip. The data keeps it honest.

Every travel site in this market shows you a filter, a list and 400 results. NamibWay asks four questions and hands back one finished, bookable itinerary — where to sleep, what to do, what to eat, what to drive and in what order — with the driving hours and the room prices taken from maintained data rather than from a language model's memory of Namibia.

HOW TO READ THE STATUS MARKS

RUNNING

in production today

BUILT

built and tested, never yet run with a live partner

DESIGNED

decided, not built

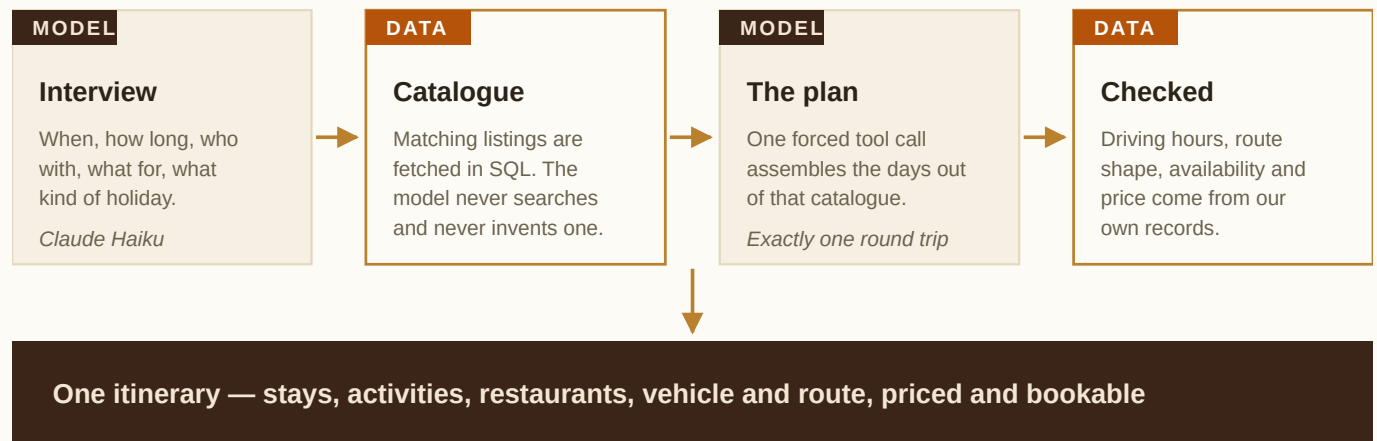
Nothing in here is a roadmap item pretending to be a feature.





A planner that does the work, not a search box that hands it back

Planning a Namibian self-drive is a research project: a dozen properties, two thousand kilometres, gravel roads that take twice as long as they look, and an order of stops that either works or ruins the holiday. Kaia does that work in a conversation and produces a plan a traveller can edit, share and book. The interesting part is not that it uses an AI model — everyone will. It is which half of the job the model is allowed to do.



The model writes the plan; it is never the source of a fact. It is handed a catalogue rather than being allowed to look for one, and everything it produces is measured against records we maintain.

WHY ONE CALL AND NOT A CONVERSATION LOOP

The obvious build lets the model search the catalogue over several rounds until it is satisfied. We did that, and replaced it. The catalogue is now assembled in code and handed over in a single forced tool call, so the number of model round trips per plan is **fixed at one**.

Three things follow. It is fast enough to feel like an answer rather than a job. It is **predictable** — a plan cannot wander off into a property that does not exist, because the only properties in the request are ours. And it is cheap: our own estimate is roughly **USD 0.15 to 0.50 of model cost for a complete planning session**, against a commission on a multi-thousand-dollar trip. Planning is not where this business spends money.

FACTS THE MODEL IS NEVER ASKED FOR

A language model will confidently tell you how long it takes to drive from Sesriem to Swakopmund. In this market that answer is a wrecked afternoon or a night drive on a gravel road, which is the one thing every safety briefing in Namibia tells you not to do. So those answers do not come from it:

Driving times come from routing over real road geometry plus a curated city-to-city dataset we maintain. **The shape of a route** comes from curated classic routes that Kaia adapts, rather than being invented from scratch. **Availability and price** come from the property's own calendar and rate plan. The model arranges; it does not assert.



What comes back is a document you can argue with

A generated itinerary is only useful if the traveller can change it without starting again. Every part of a NamibWay plan is editable in place, and the plan re-prices and re-routes itself as it changes — no regeneration, no lost work, no starting the conversation over.

Days 4–6 · Sossusvlei
3 nights · 2 adults · self-drive

Stay · Desert lodge
Double, dinner & breakfast
3 nights · N\$ — · taxes included

THE DAY
05:00 · Dune 45 at sunrise · 4 h
13:00 · Sesriem Canyon walk · 2 h
19:30 · Dinner at the lodge

Drive to Swakopmund
— hours on the road, from routing data

Map, day order and totals update with every change

Swap anything
Every stay, activity, restaurant and vehicle offers alternatives in place.

Pick the room, at the real price
Room types and prices come from the property's own calendar and season.

Reshape the trip
Reorder days, add or drop a night, change dates, party or budget.

Share it, or print it
A read-only link for the people coming along, and a PDF for the glovebox.

One stage of a plan. **The quoted price is the price the property's own calendar and rate plan produce**, taxes and levies included — so what the plan says and what the invoice later says are the same number.

WHAT THE PLAN DOES TODAY

RUNNING

Multi-part, not just beds

Accommodation, activities, restaurants and the vehicle in one itinerary, laid out day by day with times and durations.

A real map

The route drawn between stages, so the shape of the trip is visible rather than implied by a list of towns.

Alternatives everywhere

Each line offers a short list of substitutes drawn from the same catalogue and the same region, priced the same way.

Live room prices

Season, occupancy rules and taxes reach the traveller, and a stay that crosses a season boundary prices night by night.

Vehicle class and budget

The traveller picks the kind of vehicle and a daily budget, and both narrow and order what is offered.

Five languages

English, German, Dutch, French and Spanish across the platform, on web, iOS and Android.



Nothing stands between a stranger and a finished plan

The first impression of this product is the plan, so the plan costs nothing and asks for nothing. An account is only required at the point where it starts to matter who you are — when the plan becomes durable, shared, or real money. That line is enforced on the server, not by hiding a button.

THE ACCOUNT LINE — ENFORCED SERVER-SIDE, NOT IN THE INTERFACE

NO ACCOUNT

Get a plan and play with it

- The whole Kaia conversation
- Viewing the generated plan
- Swapping items, reordering days
- Changing dates, party, budget
- Autosave, and a link back to it

Free, and deliberately frictionless

ACCOUNT REQUIRED

Keep it, or share the work

- Saving a plan to your account
- Co-planning with fellow travellers, who need identities
- Sending booking requests

A person, so a change has an author

CREATOR ONLY

Booking

Sharing a plan does not hand over the ability to book it. One trip, one responsible person — which is what keeps the request rule on the next page coherent.

An anonymous request can only ever produce an **unowned** plan; attaching one to an account is the single operation that sets an owner, and it sits behind authentication. Booking resolves the creator from the plan's edit token — **a read-only share link is refused**.

SHARING TODAY **RUNNING**

A plan has two links, not one. The **share link is read-only** and renders the plan with no editing affordances at all; the edit link is the one that can change it. If two people edit anyway, the second write is **rejected rather than silently overwriting** the first — the loser is told to reload instead of discovering the loss a week later.

WHERE THIS IS GOING **DESIGNED**

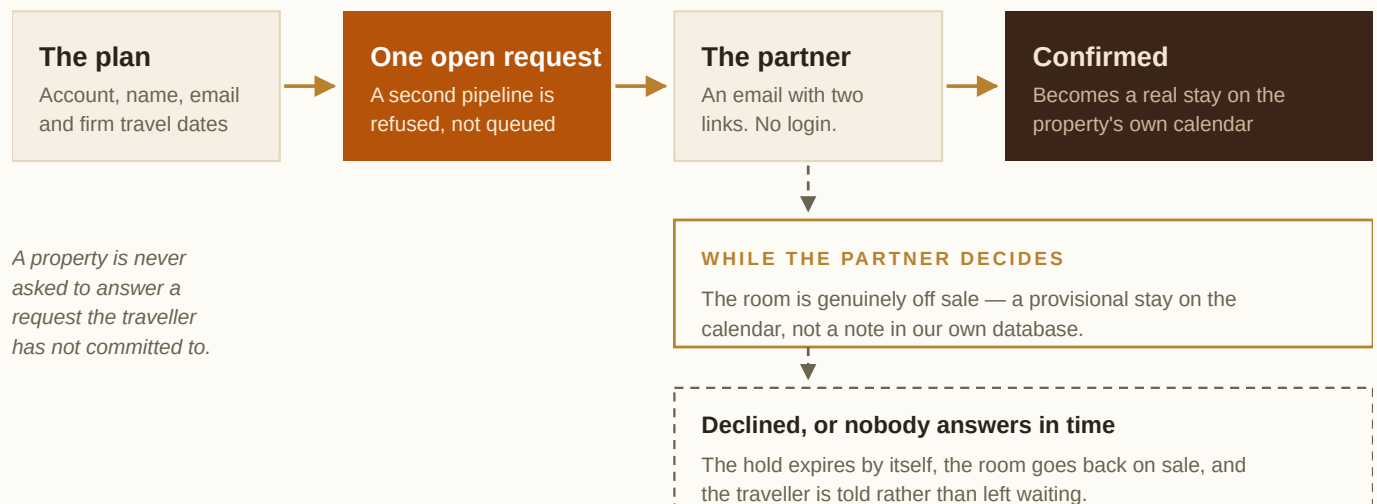
A trip is rarely planned by one person, and the read-only link is only half of that. The decided direction is a plan with **participants** — people invited with read or write access — **comments** on individual days and items with follow-ups and a resolved state, and a **log of who changed what**. That last one is what makes shared editing safe: without attribution, a co-planner's change is indistinguishable from a bug.

This is a data-model step, not a toggle, and it is not built. It is named here because it is the shape everything else in the plan is being built not to block. The same is true of the step after it: once the trip starts, the plan becomes the travelling document — which stage you are on today, what is confirmed, and the after-sales layer hanging off that one idea of "where you are". Also decided, also not built.



The hard part is turning a plan into bookings without flooding anyone

An AI planner can generate a hundred itineraries an hour. If each one sends a request to twelve lodges, the platform becomes a nuisance and the partners stop answering. The governance around the request is as much of the product as the plan is, and it is what a partner is actually being asked to trust.



The rule a partner cares about, stated plainly: **one traveller can have one open booking pipeline at a time**, and it costs them an account, real contact details and firm dates to open it.

WHAT THAT IS MADE OF

One open request	RUNNING	Checked against the account <i>and</i> the submitted email address, so a second address is not a way around it. A shortlist sent to several properties at once counts as one pipeline, checked once.
A commitment signal	RUNNING	An account plus name, email and firm travel dates before anything reaches a partner. Deliberately no payment — the signal is identity and dates, not a card.
Holds that release themselves	RUNNING	Where we hold the inventory, a request takes a provisional stay on the calendar, so the room cannot be sold twice while the answer is pending — and it comes back automatically, with the guest told.
One-click reply	RUNNING	A signed confirm and decline link in the email. No account, no password, no training — or the same action from the partner dashboard, through identical logic.
Request becomes stay	RUNNING	A confirmation promotes the request into a stay on the property's calendar exactly once, guaranteed by the database — so a partner clicking twice cannot produce two bookings.
Staged confirmations	DESIGNED	Lock the accommodation first, then layer activities and restaurants once the route is fixed. Decided, not built: today each request is handled independently.



A planner is only as good as the catalogue it plans from

The unglamorous half of this product is the content: who exists, where they actually are, what they cost, what they look like, and whether we have the right to publish any of it. That last question is answered per field and per photograph, by the software, every time something is written.

WHAT MAY REPLACE WHAT — AND WHAT MAY NEVER BE PUBLISHED

The partner's own words and photographs	Beats everything
Their own website, crawled	Beats what is below it
Our own writing, generated from the facts	Replaces the two below
Mapping and places data	A floor, not a source
— PUBLISHABLE ABOVE THIS LINE —	
Third-party directories	Internal reference only. Never published.

A listing **upgrades itself**: when a partner claims it, or when their own website is crawled, the better source replaces the weaker one. Material from a third-party directory is kept for staff to work against and **is refused publication by the software**, not by a policy somebody has to remember.

HOW THE CATALOGUE GETS FILLED

Partners, free

RUNNING

A listing costs nothing and stays free. We earn a commission only on a confirmed booking, and a listing is removed within 24 hours on request.

Claim your listing

RUNNING

An owner takes over a researched listing through an invitation link, and from then on edits their own descriptions, photographs, rooms and rates.

Bulk capture in Excel

RUNNING

Export, edit, re-import with a dry-run diff before anything is written. An empty cell means "leave this alone"; only an explicit marker clears a field.

Photographs at scale

RUNNING

Originals in object storage, thumbnails generated on demand and cached, so image bytes never pass through the application and a slow connection still gets a page.

Enrichment, budgeted

RUNNING

Finding websites, extracting structured facts, writing descriptions and scoring completeness — behind a hard daily spending cap that cannot be exceeded by a bug.

Places, not just towns

RUNNING

Regions, cities, villages and curated destinations, with coordinates as the trusted locator — which is what lets a plan route between real points.

WHY THIS IS DEFENSIBLE

Anyone can call a model. What is hard to copy is a maintained Namibian catalogue with rights-checked content, real coordinates, real room types and real prices, plus the driving dataset and the curated routes that keep a generated plan physically possible. **The model is the cheap part.**



What we will not tell you

This document is meant to be usable in front of someone who will check it. So the limits are printed next to the claims rather than left to be discovered.

DELIBERATELY ABSENT FROM THIS DOCUMENT

Traveller or booking numbers of any kind. The platform is live and the partner side is pre-launch. There are no user counts, no "trips planned" figures and no growth curves here, because there is nothing yet worth quoting and a number invented for a document is the one thing that ends a partner conversation.

No named partners, testimonials or logos. No partner is connected yet, so there is nobody to quote and no mark we have the right to print.

No validated connector integration. Adapters exist for the systems this market runs on — the dominant lodge PMS, the common channel manager, the Namibian-specific package, and a content-only itinerary system — and **not one has ever run against a real partner account.** We say "designed to connect to". We do not say "integrated with".

No commission percentage until that decision is signed off, and no promise about where a business ranks in anyone's search results.

AND THE ONE THAT MATTERS MOST TO A PARTNER

A property that lists with us is not agreeing to move its business. The listing is free, the booking requests are governed by the rule on page 5, and the partner keeps whatever system they run today. **Everything on the next two concept papers — the booking system and the websites — is something a partner may take or leave.**

THE REST OF THIS SET

The whole picture

The overview: three product lines on one shared platform, how each makes the next easier to sell, where the money comes from, and an honest map of what runs and what does not.

Booking & Payment

The lodge-facing system: an occupancy calendar, rate plans and seasons, bookings at the desk, a folio, numbered invoices, and the three settlement models we offer rather than picking one.

Websites

A website for a Namibian business, generated rather than hand-built, on one monthly fee — with live availability from the booking system where there are rooms to sell.

Come and break it

The fastest way to judge any of this is to plan a trip on namibway.com and try to catch it out — a route that cannot be driven, a price that does not add up, a plan that loses your changes. We would rather hear that from you than read it in a review.



NAMIBWAY.COM